

# Singapore



Linked to the southernmost tip of the Malay peninsula by a causeway, Singapore was established as a trading settlement in 1819. It is one of Asia's most important commercial centers.



## GEOGRAPHY

Little remains of the original vegetation on Singapore Island. The other 54 much smaller islands are little more than swampy jungle.



## CLIMATE

Equatorial. Hot and humid, with heavy rainfall all year round.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Dominated by the Chinese, who make up three-quarters of the community. The old English-speaking Straits Chinese and newer Mandarin-speakers are now well integrated. Malays are generally the poorest group. The population is skilled and industrious; there is a significant foreign workforce. Society is highly regulated; official campaigns aim to improve public behavior. Crime is limited and punishment can be severe.



## THE ECONOMY

Wealth from success as entrepôt and center of high-tech industries, such as electronics and pharmaceuticals. Leads research in new biotechnologies. All food, energy, and water imported. Worst-ever recession in 2008–2009.



**INSIGHT:** Chewing gum was banned outright from 1992 to 2004



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Singapore

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1965

**CAPITAL:** Singapore

**POPULATION:** 4.74 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 250 sq. miles  
(648 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 20,072 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Mandarin\*, Malay\*, Tamil\*, English\*

**RELIGIONS:** Buddhist 55%, Taoist 22%, Muslim 16%, Hindu, Christian, Sikh 7%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Chinese 77%, Malay 14%, Indian 8%, other 1%

**GOVERNMENT:** Parliamentary system

**CURRENCY:** Singapore dollar = 100 cents